One extremely important decision made by the organizers of the Yatra was to not confine outreach and conversations to the Congress party alone. It was made clear that the party wanted to also dialogue with members, supporters and leaders from other parties, as well as with independent civil society activists. Therefore, from the preparatory phase of the Yatra, there were groups of people associated with the party who were reaching out to civil society groups and trying to work out how regular interactions with civil society and groups representing marginalized people and communities could take place in every state and region through which the Yatra would pass.

Rahul Gandhi remained the centre point of the Yatra. Conversations that were scheduled to take place with him while he walked, and the more organized collective discussions during the lunch break, established a pattern, routine and framework for these dialogues. However, as many of us noticed, the Yatra offered an opportunity for many other simultaneous conversations with the large number of other local party leaders, civil society members, ordinary citizens, media people and political activists walking with and engaging with the entire Yatra. These conversations connected with the dialogues taking place as most of them were uploaded the same day as short videos and social media messages that were keenly watched by everyone. Many of the conversations with other leaders and activists helped set up meetings, and highlight issues and initiatives that the Yatra and Rahul Gandhi would take up in the days to come.

I watched the Yatra in its different phases, and participated in it in Karnataka (at that time a BJP-ruled state) and as part of a civil society collective that was requested to help organize civil society interaction with the Yatra in Congress-ruled Rajasthan. After having observed Karnataka, where there were a large number of complaints against the government that were being brought to a prominent Opposition-party leader, and the party continually highlighted them, I wanted to understand how similar complaints would be dealt with in Rajasthan, where the party was in power. In the course of the Yatra, it became clear that major political parties provided an important platform for people to have important everyday